

Things You Can Do With ~て Form

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1. ~てみる — Try doing (for the first time)

The ~て **form** is an important part of Japanese grammar, and is necessary for creating many other forms. The first one we will introduce here is the ~てみる form, which indicates you will **try the verb out** (usually for the first time).

DICTIONARY	→	て FORM	→	~てみる
飲む ^の		飲んで ^の		飲んでみる ^の

Polite: 飲んでみます。

DICTIONARY	→	て FORM	→	~てみる
する		して		してみる

Polite: してみます。

Important: As a norm, you do **not** write this みる using kanji.

たべてみる！

[I'll try eating it!]

たべて見る！

[I'll eat it... and then look at it.] <— different meaning!

Examples

せんせい
先生にきいてみるね！

[I'll try asking the teacher.]

なっとう
納豆をたべてみましたか。

[Did you try eating natto (for the first time)?]

やってみてください。

[Please give it a shot!]

やってください。

[Please do it.] <— without みる, just "please do"

～**てみる** cannot mean "try" as in "**making efforts**" (i.e., struggling to do something).

にほんご
日本語をべんきょうしてみる。

[I'll give Japanese a go (for the first time).]

にほんご
日本語をべんきょうしようとしている。

[I'm making efforts to study Japanese.] <— this is for "struggling / trying hard"

2. ～**ておく** — Do in advance / in preparation

The second form is ～**ておく**, which indicates that something is **done in advance / in preparation**.

DICTIONARY	→	て FORM	→	～ておく
の 飲む		の 飲んで		の 飲んでおく

Polite: の
飲んでおきます。

DICTIONARY



て FORM



～ておく

する

して

しておく

Polite: しておきます。

Important: As a norm, you do **not** write this おく using kanji.

たべておく！

[I'll eat in advance!]

たべて置く！

[I'll eat it... and then put it down.] <— different meaning!

Examples

^{ふく} ^{あら}
服を洗っておいた。

[I washed the clothes in preparation.]

でかけるまえに^{じゅうしょ}住所をしらべておきましょう。

[Let's be sure to look up the address before we head out (so we are prepared).]

^{あした}
明日のランチをつくっておくね。

[I'll get tomorrow's lunch ready early, okay?]

まいしゅう、クラスのためにいろいろな^{ほん}本をよんでおきます。

[Every week, I read many books in order to be ready for class.]

3. ～てほしい — Want something done (by someone)

The third form is ～てほしい, which means **you want the verb done** (by someone).

⚠️ Avoid this when requesting from superiors.

DICTIONARY	→	て FORM	→	～てほしい
飲む ^の		飲んで ^の		飲んでほしい ^の

Polite: 飲んでほしいです。

DICTIONARY	→	て FORM	→	～てほしい
する		して		してほしい

Polite: してほしいです。

To request politely, use ～もらえませんか instead.

もういっかい^{せつめい}説明してもらえませんか。

[Could I receive the favor of another explanation?]

→ [Could you please explain it again?]

Examples

これをかたづけてほしい。

[I want you to tidy this up.]

いってほしくなかったです。

[I didn't want (someone) to go.]

To mark the **specific person** you want to do something, use the particle **に**.

あなたにあやまってほしい。

[I want you to apologize (to me).]

かれにいわれてほしかったです。

[I wanted to be told by him.]

4. ～て (continued...) — Arriving / done / continuing

Finally, the ～て form can be used with verbs like **いる** to indicate that something **is arriving, is done, or has continued up until now** (i.e., the ～ている form). This was partially covered on the original last page.

～ている has three main uses:

- **Progressive** — an action is ongoing (*I am eating*)
- **Resultant state** — a completed action's result remains (*I am married / The door is closed*)
- **Habitual / repeated** — something done regularly (*I go to the gym every day*)

いま めし た
今、飯を食べている。

[I am eating right now.] (progressive)

けっこん
結婚している。

[I am married.] (resultant state — the action of marrying happened and the state continues)

しんぶん よ
まいあさ新聞を読んでいる。

[I read the newspaper every morning.] (habitual)

Summary Table

Form	Meaning	Example
～ てみる	Try doing (for the first time)	^{なっとう} 納豆をたべてみる。 — I'll try natto.
～ ておく	Do in advance / in preparation	^{あら} 洗っておく。 — I'll wash it in advance.
～ てほしい	Want someone to do something	きてほしい。 — I want you to come.
～ ている	Progressive / result / habitual	^た 食べている。 — I'm eating / I've eaten (and still...)

Based on the original document by Dr. Wes Robertson — reformatted for clarity.